



HENRI FARMAN

HENRI FARMAN (1874–1958), the son of a British journalist, was brought up in France. Although he sometimes wrote his first name as “Henry,” he never spoke English. Farman originally sought to satisfy his adventurous and unconventional temperament in the Bohemian lifestyle of a Parisian art student, but soon found headier excitement in the pursuit of speed. In the 1890s he took up the new sport of bicycle racing, and from there progressed to automobile racing. In

1907 he transferred his sporting prowess and mechanical know-how to the new craze for heavier-than-air flying machines. His successes as a pilot soon made him one of the most famous men in France and reasonably wealthy. He used his money to set up an aircraft factory, enjoying immediate success with a box-kite biplane. His brother Maurice became a partner in the enterprise and, in 1912, the Farmans became France’s largest aircraft manufacturers, producing over 12,000 military aircraft during WWI. The company was taken over by the state in 1936.

resembled the Wright flying machine – pusher biplanes with a forward elevator – but they had a box-kite tail structure and lacked any form of lateral control. During 1907, Parisian sculptor Léon Delagrangé and sportsman Henri Farman each turned up at the Voisin factory, coming away with his own individually modified version of the biplane. Both men quickly taught themselves to fly, logging up a series of increasingly impressive flights.

As a competitive sportsman, Henri Farman’s chief target after learning to fly was to win the 50,000-franc Deutsch-Archdeacon prize for the first person to fly a $\frac{3}{4}$ -mile (1-km) circuit. On January 13, 1908, at Issy-les-Moulineaux outside Paris, a committee of the Aéro-Club de France gathered to witness Farman’s attempt. At a signal from the pilot, two assistants holding the aircraft by its wingtips let go and the airplane raced forward, lifting into the air. Using the rudder alone, Farman made a wide, flat turn around a pylon placed $\frac{1}{3}$ mile (0.5km) from the start, returning safely to his starting point. The feat was hailed throughout Europe as an historic first, even though the Wrights had achieved the same feat – with smooth, banked turns – in 1904.

In June, Delagrangé stayed aloft for more than 18 minutes, and the following month, Curtiss won the Scientific American trophy in his *June Bug*, for the first flight of over a mile. Then on



CHECKING THE CONTROLS

Henri Farman, at the controls of a Voisin-Farman biplane, prepares to take two passengers for a ride (left). The postcard above commemorates Farman’s historic first “town-to-town” flight from Bouy to Reims on October 30, 1908.